

Stress Management Toolkit

Build Resilience Under Pressure

Understanding Stress

Stress isn't the enemy. Chronic, unmanaged stress is.

Acute Stress (Good):

- Exercise
- Cold exposure
- Public speaking
- Challenges

Chronic Stress (Bad):

- Poor sleep
- Overwork
- Relationship issues
- Financial worry

The goal: Build resilience through controlled stress + recovery.

The Stress Response

When stressed, your body releases:

- Cortisol (stress hormone)
- Adrenaline (fight or flight)

Short-term: Helpful

Long-term: Destructive

Signs of chronic stress:

- Poor sleep
- Low energy
- Irritability
- Brain fog
- Weakened immune system

- Weight gain (especially belly)

Breathwork for Stress

Box Breathing (Immediate Calm):

1. Inhale 4 seconds
2. Hold 4 seconds
3. Exhale 4 seconds
4. Hold 4 seconds
5. Repeat 4-5 rounds

Physiological Sigh (Quick Reset):

1. Deep inhale through nose
2. Second inhale (top off lungs)
3. Long exhale through mouth
4. Repeat 2-3 times

Use before:

- Important meetings
- Difficult conversations
- High-pressure situations

Meditation Practice

Start Small: 5 Minutes Daily

Simple Protocol:

1. Sit comfortably
2. Close eyes
3. Focus on breath
4. When mind wanders, return to breath
5. No judgment, just awareness

Benefits (after 30 days):

- Reduced anxiety
- Better focus
- Improved emotional regulation
- Lower blood pressure

- Enhanced sleep

Best times:

- Morning (after waking)
- Midday (reset)
- Evening (wind-down)

Time Blocking & Boundaries

Protect Your Energy

Deep Work Blocks:

- 90-120 minutes
- No interruptions
- Phone off
- Single focus
- 2-3 blocks per day

Break Protocol:

- 5 min every hour
- 15 min every 2 hours
- Walk, stretch, breathe

Boundaries:

- No email after 6 PM
- No work on weekends
- No phone in bedroom
- Say no to non-essentials

Nature & Movement

Nature Exposure (Daily):

- 15-30 minutes outdoors
- Natural light
- Fresh air
- Grounding (barefoot on grass)

Benefits:

- Reduced cortisol
- Improved mood
- Better sleep
- Enhanced creativity

Movement for Stress:

- Walking
- Yoga
- Swimming
- Hiking

Avoid:

- Excessive high-intensity training
- Overtraining when stressed

The Stress Audit

Weekly Review:

- Sleep quality (7-9 hours)
- Breathwork practice (daily)
- Meditation (5+ min/day)
- Nature exposure (15+ min/day)
- Deep work blocks (2-3/day)
- Boundaries maintained
- Recovery activities

If stress is high:

- Increase sleep
- Reduce training intensity
- Add breathwork
- Spend time in nature
- Simplify schedule